# Cycles and Functionality in cvc5's Relations Solver

## `rel.cyclic`, `rel.is-functional` and their calculus

the pull request to cvc5 main (branch `cycle-ext-cyclic`)

October 2026

# Outline


1. Motivation
2. What is new compared to cvc5 main
3. The calculus
4. Strategy
5. Last call and model construction
6. Results
7. Summary

# Relational specifications need acyclicity and functionality

**Axiomatic memory models** allow an execution iff some union of relations is acyclic, e.g. sequential consistency: $po \cup rf \cup co \cup fr$ is acyclic.
**Alloy-style specifications** constrain relations to be (partial) functions.

**In cvc5 main** both properties must be stated with quantifiers:

$$\forall x.\ (x, x) \notin TC(R)$$
$$\forall x\, y\, z.\ (x, y) \in R \wedge (x, z) \in R \Rightarrow y = z$$

and the negation of acyclicity needs an existential witness. Instantiation (E-matching or finite model finding) has to find the right instances.

**With this PR**, two predicates that the relations solver reasons about directly:

```
; a forbidden execution: a cycle
(assert (rel.cyclic
  (set.union po (set.union rf
    (set.union co fr)))))
; po is acyclic and functional
(assert (not (rel.cyclic po)))
(assert (rel.is-functional po))
```

No quantifier for acyclicity or functionality; a calculus of inference rules instead (this talk).

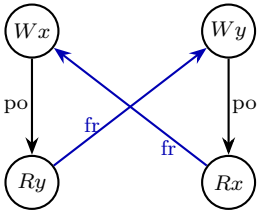
# The benchmarks: completeness of litmus-test templates

13 memory-model benchmarks (relational-solver-benchmarks): SC, SC per location (plsc), TSO; one and two threads; variants `just-rf` and `no-ltts`.

Each asks: *is there an execution that violates the memory model but that no litmus-test template forbids?*

- `unsat`: the templates are complete (10 files);
- `sat`: cvc5 prints such an execution (3 files).

The violation is a cycle: `(rel.cyclic (set.union po rf co fr))`; the templates and the model are acyclicity and functionality constraints on the derived relations.




store buffering: a cycle of po ∪ fr, forbidden by SC

# The changes at a glance

| component | change |
|---|---|
| kinds, API | `RELATION_CYCLIC` (`rel.cyclic`), `RELATION_IS_FUNCTIONAL` (`rel.is-functional`), `RELATION_RCLOSURE`, `RELATION_RTCLOSURE` (`rel.rclosure`, `rel.rtclosure`); parser, printer, CPC signature |
| type rules | a binary relation whose columns have the same sort (cyclic, closures); any binary relation (functional) |
| rewriter | evaluation and elimination rules (constants, empty set, singletons, unions) |
| relations solver | the calculus: cycle witness, minimality, acyclicity, anchors, closure induction, functionality, lazy closure splits, grounding conflicts |
| strategy | a new full-effort step, three last-call steps, `needsCheckLastEffort` |
| options | `--rels-functional-mode`, `--rels-acyclic-anchor`, `--rels-acyclic-backward-chords`, `--rels-tc-subset`, `--rels-tc-down-lazy`, `--rels-acyclic-hammer` |
| defaults | MiniSat under `--sets-exp` (justification heuristic), except for sygus-style problems |
| fixes | closure rules (edge explanations, conclusions on the tuple of the explanation); no redundant facts in the sets solver |
| tests, docs | 53 regression files; `docs/theories/sets-and-relations.rst` |

Against cvc5 main (a3f47bdffd): 28 source files, +3305/ − 131 lines; tests +1958 lines.
`scripts/` (experiment scripts, these slides) is temporary.

# New predicates

`(rel.cyclic R)`, $R$ : `(Relation T T)`

$$\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \iff \exists x.\ (x, x) \in R^+$$

Acyclicity is `(not (rel.cyclic R))`.

e.g. `(rel.cyclic (set.union R S))` holds for $R = \{(a, b)\}$, $S = \{(b, a)\}$; `(rel.cyclic R)` and `(rel.cyclic S)` do not.

`(rel.is-functional R)`, $R$ : `(Relation T1 T2)`

$$\mathsf{fun}(R) \iff \forall x\, y\, z.\ (x, y), (x, z) \in R \Rightarrow y = z$$

Right-unique, not necessarily total.

`(rel.rclosure R)`, `(rel.rtclosure R)`

$R$ plus $(x, x)$ for every $x$ in its domain or range; and that union with $R^+$. Eliminated by rewriting when $R$ is built from $\emptyset$, singletons and unions; otherwise the solver answers `unknown`.

**Why a predicate and not a definition?**
The definitions need a quantifier (or the universe set, which cvc5 does not interpret as all elements). As predicates, the solver builds *witnesses* and *explanations* for them, and uses their structure (unions, closures, joins) in its rules.

# Rewrite rules: what holds in every context

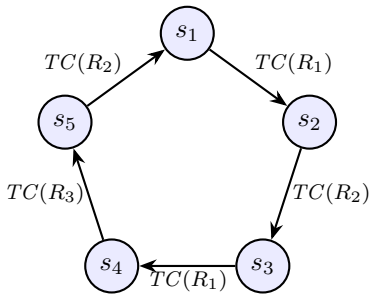
The rewriter only replaces a term by an *equivalent* term, independently of the assertions:

| term | rewritten to | why |
|---|---|---|
| `(rel.cyclic ∅)` | `false` | no pair at all |
| `(rel.cyclic {(x,y)})` | `(= x y)` | only a self-loop |
| `(rel.cyclic` $c$`)`, $c$ constant | `true` / `false` | evaluate $c^+$ |
| `(rel.is-functional X)`, $X$: ∅, `{t}`, `(rel.iden A)` | `true` | at most one image |
| `(rel.is-functional` $c$`)`, $c$ constant | `true` / `false` | first components |
| `(rel.rclosure {(x,y)})` | $\{(y,y)\} \cup (\{(x,x)\} \cup \{(x,y)\})$ | definition |
| `(rel.rclosure (set.union A B))` | `(rel.rclosure A)` ∪ `(rel.rclosure B)` | union |
| `(rel.rtclosure R)` | `(rel.rclosure R)` ∪ `(rel.tclosure R)` | definition |

Everything else is done by *inference rules* in the relations solver (next section).

# Notation

- A configuration: the asserted literals and the equivalence classes of the equality engine; $t \sim t'$: equal in the current context.
- A rule $\dfrac{P_1 \quad \dots \quad P_n}{C}$ sends the *lemma* $P_1 \wedge \dots \wedge P_n \Rightarrow C$, a valid clause whose premises are the explanation (used by conflict analysis, unsat cores and proofs).
- Fresh symbols are skolems, cached by their key, so each is created once.
- The *cycle witness* of $\mathsf{cyclic}(R_1 \cup \dots \cup R_k)$: elements $s_1, \dots, s_l$ with $s_l = s_1$ ($l - 1$ edges), each edge in some $TC(R_j)$.




$l = 6,\ s_6 = s_1$

# Cyclicity: creating and unrolling the witness

For an asserted $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ (fresh $s$, $s_1$, $l$, $s_{i+1}$):

$$\frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \quad R \text{ not a union}}{(s,s) \in TC(R)}\ \textsc{Cycle-Def} \qquad \frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R_1 \cup \cdots \cup R_k)}{1 < l}\ \textsc{Inst-Cycle}$$

$$\frac{i < l}{(s_i, s_{i+1}) \in TC(R_1) \ \vee \ \ldots \ \vee \ (s_i, s_{i+1}) \in TC(R_k)}\ \textsc{Unroll}$$

$$\frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \quad i \leq l}{i < l \ \vee \ (l = i \wedge s_i = s_1)}\ \textsc{Split-Len} \qquad \frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R') \quad R' \text{ has the operands of } R}{\mathsf{cyclic}(R)}\ \textsc{Same-Operands}$$

- The operands of nested unions are flattened: the witness of $\mathsf{cyclic}(rf \cup (po \cup co))$ alternates between $TC(rf)$, $TC(po)$, $TC(co)$.
- One Unroll per check round; at last call the witness is completed to the value of $l$ in the candidate model.
- Unroll needs no $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ premise: if $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ is false, $l$ is unconstrained and $l \leq 1$ makes every instance vacuous.

# Minimality: the witness is a shortest cycle

The witness can be a shortest cycle of $TC(R_1) \cup \cdots \cup TC(R_k)$ ($q < r \leq l$, every $R_j$):

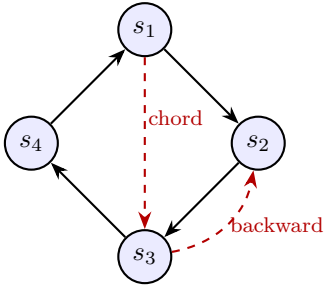
$$\frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \quad i < l}{\neg\big((s_{i-1}, s_i) \in TC(R_j) \wedge (s_i, s_{i+1}) \in TC(R_j)\big)}\ \textsc{Alternate}$$

$$\frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \quad l = i + 1}{\neg\big((s_i, s_{i+1}) \in TC(R_j) \wedge (s_1, s_2) \in TC(R_j)\big)}\ \textsc{Alt-Close}$$

$$\frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \quad r \leq l \quad q < r - 1}{(s_q, s_r) \notin TC(R_j)}\ \textsc{Chord}$$

$$\frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \quad r \leq l \quad (q, r) \neq (1, l)}{s_q \neq s_r}\ \textsc{Distinct}$$

**Backward** (`--rels-acyclic-backward-chords`): $(s_r, s_q) \notin TC(R_j)$ if it closes a shorter cycle; lets a totality axiom (e.g. *po*) bound the witness.




$l = 5$: both dashed edges would give a shorter cycle

# Acyclicity

For an asserted $\neg\mathsf{cyclic}(u)$:

$$\frac{(a,b) \in TC(R) \qquad \neg\mathsf{cyclic}(u) \qquad u \sim R}{a \neq b}\ \textsc{Acyclic-Down} \qquad\qquad \frac{\neg\mathsf{cyclic}(u)}{u \subseteq TC(u)}\ \textsc{Register}$$

- Acyclic-Down turns every reflexive closure membership into a conflict. The existing closure rules produce those memberships:

$$\frac{(a,b) \in R \qquad (b,c) \in TC(R)}{(a,c) \in TC(R)}\ \text{TC-Up}$$

$$\frac{(a,b) \in TC(R)}{(a,b) \in R \vee \big((a,k_1),(k_2,b) \in R \wedge (k_1 = k_2 \vee (k_1,k_2) \in TC(R))\big)}\ \text{TC-Down}$$

- Register is valid and does nothing logically: it makes $TC(u)$ a term of the solver even if the input never mentions it, so that a cycle of $u$ is found.
- The conclusion is stated on the tuple of the explanation, not on its representative (the lemma is context-independent).

# Cyclic meets acyclic: anchor rules

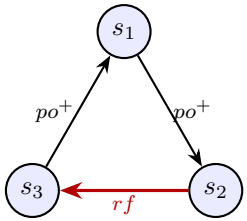
A cycle of $R$ all of whose edges lie in $TC(S)$ would be a cycle of $S$:

$$\frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \qquad \neg\mathsf{cyclic}(S)}{t \in R' \wedge t \notin TC(S)}\ \textsc{Inclusion}$$

$$\frac{\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \qquad \neg\mathsf{cyclic}(S) \qquad l = N}{\bigvee_{i<N}(s_i, s_{i+1}) \notin TC(S)}\ \textsc{Branch}$$

$t$ fresh; $R'$: the operands of $R$ *not* syntactically in $TC(S)$ (e.g. $S \cap Y$, $TC(S)$, $S;S$ are). If there is none, the lemma is `false`.

Branch is sent at last call, with $N$ the value of $l$ in the candidate model; with $l = N$ in its premises the listed edges are the whole cycle. `--rels-acyclic-anchor`: `branch` (default), `inclusion`, `both`, `none`.




$\mathsf{cyclic}(po \cup rf)$, $\neg\mathsf{cyclic}(po)$:
Inclusion gives $t \in rf$, $t \notin po^+$

# Closure induction (`--rels-tc-subset`)

$TC(R)$ is the least transitive relation that contains $R$:

$$\frac{(a,b) \in TC(R) \qquad R \subseteq S \qquad S;S \subseteq S}{(a,b) \in S}\ \text{TC-Subset}$$

The transitive supersets $S$ recognised in the current context:

| superset $S$ | recognised by | example |
|---|---|---|
| $TC(X)$, $R$ syntactically in $TC(X)$ | the shape of $R$ | $R = po^+ \cap loc$, $S = po^+$ |
| $S$ transitive, $R \subseteq S$ asserted | $(R \cup S) = S$ in the context | $S = A \times B$, a closure, $J; J^T$ with $\mathsf{fun}(J)$ |
| $R$ itself | $(R;R) \subseteq R$ asserted | $co$ transitive: $TC(co) = co$ |
| $R$ itself | $R \subseteq A \times B$, $A \cap B = \emptyset$ | $fr$ from reads to writes: $TC(fr) = fr$ |
| $X$, transitive | $R = X \cap Y$ or $R = X \setminus Y$ | |

No fresh element: where it applies, one lemma replaces an unbounded descent of TC-Down splits, each of which introduces two elements. This is what the hand proofs of the benchmarks use ("every $ghb$ path is in $po^+$").

# Functionality (`--rels-functional-mode`)

$$\frac{\mathsf{fun}(R) \qquad (x,y) \in S \qquad S \sim R}{y = f_R(x)}\ \textsc{Fun-UF} \qquad \frac{\mathsf{fun}(R) \qquad (x_1,y_1) \in R \qquad (x_2,y_2) \in R}{x_1 = x_2 \Rightarrow y_1 = y_2}\ \textsc{Fun-Pairs}$$

$$\frac{\neg\mathsf{fun}(R)}{(k_1,k_2) \in R \wedge (k_1,k_3) \in R \wedge k_2 \neq k_3}\ \textsc{Not-Fun}$$

- `uf` (default): a fresh function $f_R$; linear in the members, congruence does the rest: $(a,b),(a,c) \in R$ give $b = f_R(a) = c$. `pairs`: quadratic, no function symbol (used when the logic has no UF).
- Feeds closure induction: $J; J^T$ is transitive if $J$ is functional ($J^T; J$ relates only equal elements), e.g. $\mathit{same\ location} = \mathit{address}; \mathit{address}^T$.

# Splitting closures and joins: eager, lazy, or not at all

**Eager** (cvc5 main): TC-Down for every closure membership that the known members do not explain, and Join-Split for every join membership, each with fresh elements. With finite model finding this floods the model with elements.

$$\frac{(x,z) \in A;B}{(x,k) \in A \wedge (k,z) \in B}\ \textsc{Join-Split} \qquad \frac{(x,y) \in A \quad (y,z) \in B}{(x,z) \in A;B}\ \textsc{Join-Compose}$$

**Lazy** (`--rels-tc-down-lazy`): TC-Down only at last call, and only for memberships that the known members of $R$ do not explain. Unsat proofs that never unfold a closure (closure induction) introduce no element.

**Not at all** (`--rels-acyclic-hammer`, for unsat problems): no TC-Down and no Join-Split. At last call, a closure or join membership that the known members do not explain is a conflict (Ground-TC, Ground-Join; see *Grounding at last call*).

Lazy and hammer move element introduction for closures and joins out of the full-effort check: the last call either introduces them only where needed (lazy) or refutes the candidate model instead (hammer).

# Why inference rules and not rewrite rules?

### The rewriter

maps a term to an *equivalent* term:

- the same in every context (no access to assertions or to the model);
- no fresh symbols, no case splits;
- terminating, and applied to the input and to every lemma.

It gets the rules on the term alone: $\mathsf{cyclic}(\emptyset) = \bot$, $\mathsf{cyclic}(\{(x, y)\}) = (x = y)$, constants, closure elimination.

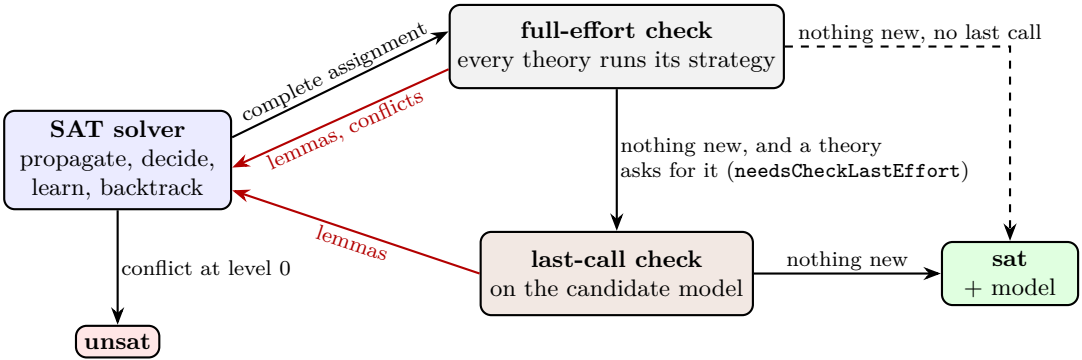
Rewriting $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ to its definition needs a quantifier, or $TC(R) \cap \mathit{iden}(\mathit{univ}) \neq \emptyset$, which is wrong in cvc5 (the universe is not all elements) and hides the structure the rules use.

| the rules need | e.g. |
|---|---|
| a **witness** (an existential: fresh symbols) | Cycle-Def, Inst-Cycle, Unroll, Inclusion, Not-Fun |
| **case splits** for the SAT solver | Unroll picks an operand, Split-Len continues or closes |
| **other asserted facts** | TC-Subset ($R \subseteq S$, $S$ transitive), anchors ($\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ and $\neg\mathsf{cyclic}(S)$), Fun-UF (a membership) |
| **equivalence classes** | $S \sim R$, $u \sim R$: premises that hold now, not always |
| **the candidate model** | Branch ($l = N$), Ground-TC, Ground-Join |
| **unbounded** unfolding | a witness of any length, one element per round |

# Soundness

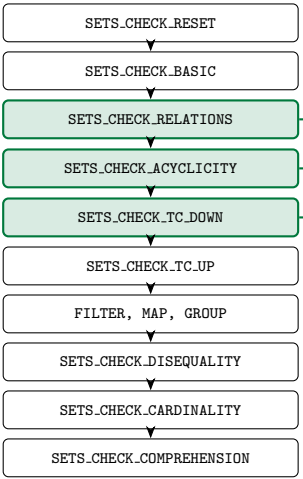
- **Valid lemmas**, consequences of the definitions and the premises: the closure rules, Acyclic-Down, Register, TC-Subset, Fun-Pairs, and the grounding conflicts (their premises contain $S = TC(R)$ or $S = A; B$ and the disequalities that block every derivation).
- **Lemmas about skolems**, satisfiability-preserving: any model of the input extends to one in which the witness is a shortest cycle of the operands' closures, $f_R$ maps every element to its image, etc. This covers Cycle-Def, Inst-Cycle, Unroll, Split-Len, Alternate, Alt-Close, Chord, Distinct, Backward, Inclusion, Fun-UF, Not-Fun. Branch follows from them (thanks to $l = N$). The last call sends instances of the same rules (see *Is introducing elements at last call sound?*).
- **Incompleteness is reported**, so cvc5 answers `unknown` instead of a wrong `sat`, when
  - the length of a witness has no practical value in the model;
  - a `rel.rclosure` term is not eliminated by rewriting.
- **Proofs.** The lemmas are trusted theory lemmas; their CPC proofs check with ethos (`rel.cyclic`, `rel.is-functional` are in the CPC signature).

# Where the rules run: cvc5's DPLL($T$) loop




- The sets theory asks for a last call (`needsCheckLastEffort`) if a cycle witness exists, or under `--rels-tc-down-lazy` / `--rels-acyclic-hammer` if closures or joins occur.
- Lemmas are permanent clauses; the witness and the caches are rolled back on backtracking (context-dependent).

# The sets strategy at full effort



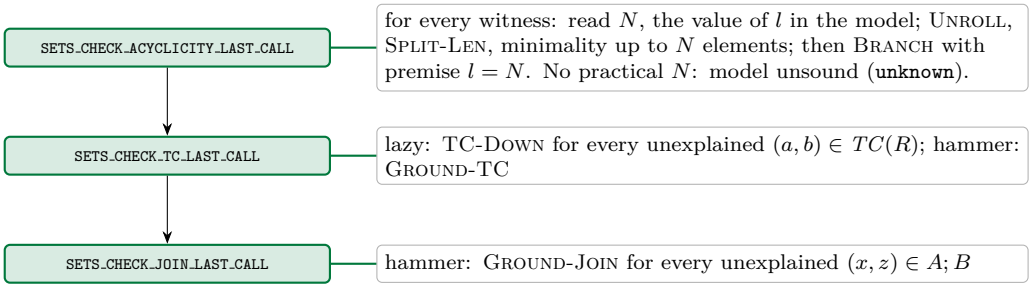

**relations**: collect the asserted literals and terms; CYCLE-DEF, INST-CYCLE, SAME-OPERANDS, REGISTER, NOT-FUN; per membership the join, product, transpose and identity rules, ACYCLIC-DOWN; FUN-UF / FUN-PAIRS

**new step**: per witness one UNROLL, SPLIT-LEN, ALTERNATE, ALT-CLOSE, CHORD, DISTINCT, BACKWARD, INCLUSION; BRANCH for self-loops

**closures**: TC-DOWN (deferred if lazy, skipped by the hammer) and TC-SUBSET per closure membership; no break: TC-UP runs in the same round

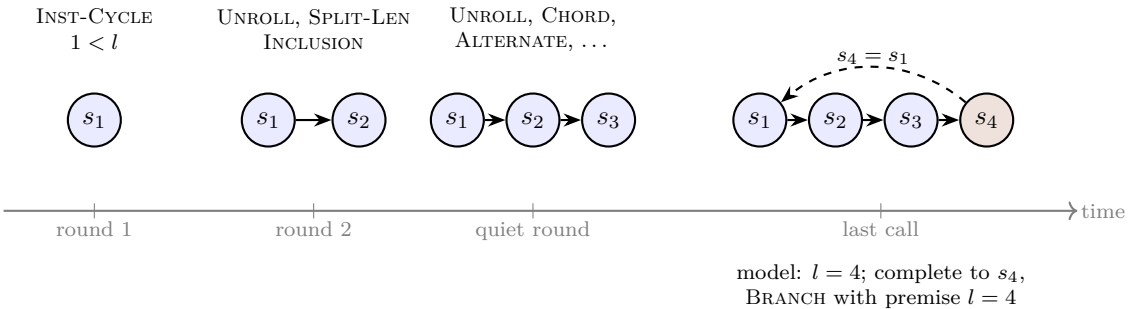
After each step (a *break*): if the step sent a lemma or a fact, the round stops. Facts only: the strategy runs again; a lemma: back to the SAT solver. Green: new or changed by this PR. TC: `TRANSITIVE_CLOSURE`.

# Last call: the candidate model decides




- A step that sends a lemma ends the check; the SAT solver continues with it.
- Model-dependent rules belong here: at full effort the length of the witness is still symbolic, and the members of a relation are not final.

# A cycle witness across the search




- Each round's lemmas go back to the SAT solver; a conflict may backtrack past the creation of $s_3$, which then disappears from the witness. It is recreated, as the same skolem, with lemmas that are already known: that round is quiet, and the last call runs.
- A witness that is too long for the problem is refuted by minimality and the anchors; a short one survives and its edges become the model's cycle.

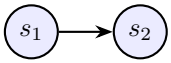
# Last call: completing the witness

**Algorithm 1:** `checkAcyclicityLastCall`

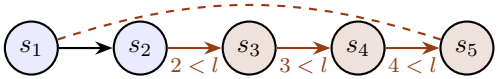
```
1  foreach witness s_1..s_c, l of an asserted
     cyclic(R_1 ∪ ··· ∪ R_k) do
2      N ← the value of l in the candidate model
3      if N is not a constant, or N > 10000 then
4          LEN-UNKNOWN: model unsound; continue
5      while c < N do
6          s_{c+1} ← the skolem cached for (R, c + 1)
7          send UNROLL_c, ALTERNATE_c, ALT-CLOSE_c
8          c ← c + 1
9          send SPLIT-LEN_c, and CHORD, DISTINCT,
10             BACKWARD for the pairs up to s_c
11     if N ≥ 2 then
12         foreach asserted ¬cyclic(S) do
13             send BRANCH_N (once per R, S, N)
```

A lemma that was sent before is not sent again (the lemma cache survives backtracking).

current context: $c = 2$; model: $l = 5$




after the last call: $c = 5$




SPLIT-LEN$_5$: $l = 5 \Rightarrow s_5 = s_1$

- **Why** $c < N$: full effort adds one element per round, backtracking removes them. Re-unrolled with the same skolems, a round sends only known lemmas: it is quiet, and the last call runs. Each new edge (orange) has its own guard $i < l$.

# The lemmas about the witness

Each lemma is *premise* $\Rightarrow$ *conclusion*, for the witness of $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$, $R = R_1 \cup \cdots \cup R_k$, and every operand $R_j$:

| rule | premise | | conclusion |
|---|---|---|---|
| Inst-Cycle | $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ | | $1 < l$ |
| Unroll$_i$ | $i < l$ | | $(s_i, s_{i+1}) \in TC(R_1) \vee \cdots \vee (s_i, s_{i+1}) \in TC(R_k)$ |
| Split-Len$_r$ | $\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \wedge r \leq l$ | | $r < l \ \vee \ (l = r \wedge s_r = s_1)$ |
| Alternate$_i$ | $\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \wedge i < l$ | $(i \geq 2)$ | $\neg\big((s_{i-1}, s_i) \in TC(R_j) \wedge (s_i, s_{i+1}) \in TC(R_j)\big)$ |
| Alt-Close$_i$ | $\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \wedge l = i + 1$ | $(i \geq 2)$ | $\neg\big((s_i, s_{i+1}) \in TC(R_j) \wedge (s_1, s_2) \in TC(R_j)\big)$ |
| Chord$_{q,r}$ | $\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \wedge r \leq l$ | $(q < r - 1)$ | $(s_q, s_r) \notin TC(R_j)$ |
| Distinct$_{q,r}$ | $\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \wedge r \leq l$ [$\wedge\, r \neq l$ if $q = 1$] | | $s_q \neq s_r$ |
| Branch$_N$ | $\mathsf{cyclic}(R) \wedge \neg\mathsf{cyclic}(S) \wedge l = N$ | | $(s_1, s_2) \notin TC(S) \vee \cdots \vee (s_{N-1}, s_N) \notin TC(S)$ |
| Len-Unknown | $l$ has no value $\leq 10000$ | | model unsound: `unknown`, never `sat` |

- The premises mention the term $l$, never its value. $N$ only decides *how many* instances the last call sends, and appears only as the literal $l = N$ of Branch$_N$.
- $s_i$ is the skolem cached for $(R, i)$: full effort and the last call build the same element and lemma. The last call changes *when* a lemma is sent, not *what* it says.

# Is introducing elements at last call sound? (1/2)

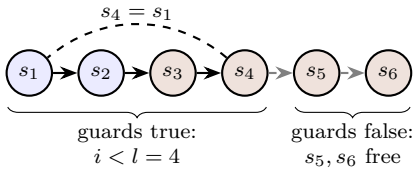
**Claim**: every model $M$ of the input extends to a model $M'$ that satisfies the lemmas about the witness *for all indices and all $N$ at once*: whatever values of $l$ the candidate models show, no model of the input is lost (no wrong `unsat`).

$M'$ interprets only the skolems:

- $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ true in $M$: take a *shortest* cycle of $TC(R_1) \cup \cdots \cup TC(R_k)$ in $M$, with $L - 1$ edges. Set $l := L$, put $s_1, \ldots, s_L$ along the cycle ($s_L = s_1$), and let $s_i$, $i > L$, be any element.
- $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ false in $M$: $l := 1$, every $s_i$ any element.

Every guard of an index beyond $L$ ($i < l$, $r \leq l$, $l = N$) is false in $M'$: the elements created for a larger value of $l$ are unconstrained.

an earlier candidate model had $l = 6$, so a last call created $s_3, \ldots, s_6$; the final model has $l = 4$




- A shortest cycle exists if a cycle does; no edge of a $TC(R_j)$ shortcuts it.
- Other rules on the $s_i$ (TC-Down, ...) are valid or pick their own fresh elements after the $s_i$.

# Is introducing elements at last call sound? (2/2)

Every lemma holds in $M'$ ($\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ true in $M$, shortest cycle with $L-1$ edges, $G = TC(R_1) \cup \cdots \cup TC(R_k)$):

| rule | index up to $L$: the guard holds, the conclusion too | index beyond $L$ |
|---|---|---|
| Inst-Cycle | $1 < L$: the cycle has an edge | — |
| Unroll$_i$ | $i < L$: $(s_i, s_{i+1})$ is an edge of the cycle, so it is in some $TC(R_j)$ | $i < l$ false |
| Split-Len$_r$ | $r < L$: $r < l$; $r = L$: $l = L$ and $s_L = s_1$ | $r \leq l$ false |
| Alternate$_i$, Alt-Close$_i$ | two consecutive edges in $TC(R_j)$ give, by transitivity, one edge of $TC(R_j)$: a cycle of $G$ with one edge less | $i < l$, $l = i + 1$ false |
| Chord$_{q,r}$ | $(s_q, s_r) \in TC(R_j)$ skips $r - q \geq 2$ edges: a shorter cycle (for $(1, L)$: a self-loop, 1 edge) | $r \leq l$ false |
| Distinct$_{q,r}$ | $s_q = s_r$ closes the cycle $s_q..s_r$ of $r - q < L - 1$ edges | $r \leq l$ false |
| Branch$_N$ | $N \neq L$: $l = N$ is false. $N = L$: if every edge were in $TC(S)$, $S$ would be cyclic in $M$, but $M \models \neg\mathsf{cyclic}(S)$ | — |

$\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ **false in** $M$: every premise contains $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$, except Unroll$_i$, whose guard $i < l = 1$ is false.

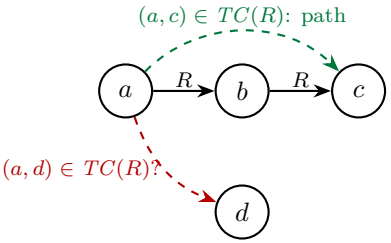
**The other direction** (no wrong `sat`): a quiet last call means that the model satisfies Unroll$_1$..Unroll$_{N-1}$ and Split-Len$_N$ with $l = N$: it has a cycle (see *Model construction*). Without a practical $N$: `unknown`.

# Grounding at last call: the algorithm

**Algorithm 2:** last call: closures, joins

```
1 collect the members of every relation, by representatives
2 foreach membership (a, b) ∈ TC(R) do
3     if no path a → ··· → b in the graph of the known
        members of R then
4         if lazy then send TC-Down for (a, b)
5         else send Ground-TC                    (hammer)
6 if hammer then
7     foreach membership (x, z) ∈ A; B do
8         if no known (x, y) ∈ A with (y, z) ∈ B then
9             send Ground-Join
```

- Closure (`isTCReachable`): depth-first search from $a$ over the members of $R$ only.
- Join (`isJoinReachable`): for each known $(x, y) \in A$, look up $(y, z)$ in the membership trie of $B$.



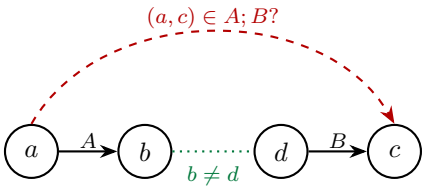

$R = \{(a, b), (b, c)\}$: $(a, c)$ is explained, $(a, d)$ is not.

- lazy: TC-Down adds $(a, k_1), (k_2, d) \in R$, $\ldots$;
- hammer: Ground-TC refutes this model: the SAT solver must change $R$, an equality, or the membership.

# Grounding conflict: GROUND-JOIN

$$\frac{(x,z) \in S \quad S = A;B \quad A = \{(x_1,y_1),..,(x_n,y_n)\} \quad B = \{(u_1,z_1),..,(u_m,z_m)\} \quad x_i \neq x \ \vee \ y_i \neq u_j \ \vee \ z_j \neq z \quad \text{for all } i,j}{\bot} \ \text{GROUND-JOIN}$$

no pair of members composes to $(x, z)$




$(a, c) \in A; B$, $A = \{(a, b)\}$, $B = \{(d, c)\}$: one pair,

$$\underbrace{a \neq a}_{\text{false}} \vee b \neq d \vee \underbrace{c \neq c}_{\text{false}}$$

The lemma keeps one true disjunct per pair:

$$\neg\big((a,c) \in S \wedge S = A;B \wedge A = \{(a,b)\} \wedge B = \{(d,c)\} \wedge b \neq d\big)$$

Before: *distinct*$(a, b, c, d)$; every merge of two other elements (e.g. $a = c$) needed a new conflict (12 instead of 1).

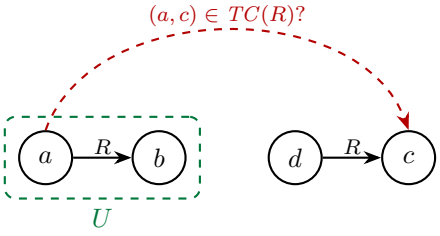
# Grounding conflict: GROUND-TC

$$\frac{(x,z) \in S \quad S = TC(R) \quad R = \{(p_1,q_1),..,(p_n,q_n)\} \qquad p_i \notin U \ \vee \ (q_i \in U \wedge q_i \neq z) \quad \text{for all } i}{\bot} \ \text{GROUND-TC}$$

where $U = \{x\} \cup \{\, q \mid (p,q) \in R, \ \ M \models p = x \vee (x,p) \in TC(R) \,\}$:

$x$ and the target $q$ of every member $(p,q)$ of $R$ whose source $p$ is $x$ or reachable from $x$, in the current model $M$; $p \notin U$ stands for $p \neq u$ for all $u \in U$

every edge from $U$ stays in $U$ and misses $z$: $z$ is not reachable from $x$




$(a,c) \in TC(R)$, $R = \{(a,b),(d,c)\}$: $U = \{a,b\}$ ($b$ is reached by $(a,b)$):

- $(a,b)$: $a \in U$, so $b \in U \wedge b \neq c$;
- $(d,c)$: $d \notin U$, i.e. $d \neq a \wedge d \neq b$.

Each is needed: $b = c$, $d = a$ or $d = b$ makes $(a,c)$ a member. Before: $\mathit{distinct}(a,b,c,d)$, 7 conflicts instead of 1.

# Grounding conflicts: the premise $S = A; B$, and the phase

$S = A; B$: the membership may be on a set $S$ equal to the join only in the current branch:

$$(a, c) \in S \qquad S = A; B \ \vee \ S = T \qquad A = \{(a, b)\} \qquad B = \{(d, c)\} \qquad \mathit{distinct}(a, b, c, d)$$

$S = T$ is a model. The conflict without $S = A; B$, $\neg\big((a, c) \in S \wedge \mathit{distinct}(a, b, c, d)\big)$, excluded it too: the answer was `unsat` (`--rels-acyclic-hammer`). Now $\neg\big((a, c) \in S \wedge S = A; B \wedge b \neq d\big)$: `sat`. Likewise $S = TC(R)$.

**Phase**: a conflict is satisfied by a merge (a disequality becomes false) or by a fresh member of $R$ ($R = \{..\}$ becomes false). cvc5 prefers $R = \{..\}$ true: a fresh member is unconstrained and leads to the next conflict with one more member, and such chains need not end (`rel_tc_10_1` with the hammer: 0.01 s before, timeout without the preference, 0.7 s with it).

Regressions: `rel_join_grounding_key`, `rel_join_grounding_alias`, `rel_tc_grounding_cut`, `rel_tc_grounding_cut_sat`.

# Model construction: why `sat` is correct

**How cvc5 builds the model** (`collectModelValues`): every set equivalence class gets the union of the singletons of its known members. Relational terms are *not* recomputed, so `sat` is correct only if, when the last call is quiet, the member lists agree with the operators:

| term / literal | every required member is there | every member is justified |
|---|---|---|
| $TC(R)$ | TC-Up: the pairs of every path of $R$ | TC-Down (full effort or lazy), or no unexplained member (hammer) |
| $A; B$ | Join-Compose | Join-Split, or no unexplained member (hammer) |
| $\mathsf{cyclic}(R)$ | quiet last call: $c \geq N$, and the model satisfies Unroll$_i$ ($i < N = l$) and Split-Len$_N$, so $s_1 \to \cdots \to s_N = s_1$ with every edge in some $TC(R_j)$, which is the closure of $R_j$ in the model (rows above): $R$ has a cycle. Self-loop form: $(s, s) \in TC(R)$. | |
| $\neg\mathsf{cyclic}(u)$ | Register makes $TC(u)$ a term; TC-Up puts $(a, a)$ into it for any cycle of the members of $u$; Acyclic-Down refutes that: $u$ is acyclic in the model. | |
| $\mathsf{fun}(R)$, $\neg\mathsf{fun}(R)$ | Fun-UF / Fun-Pairs: no $(x, y_1), (x, y_2)$ with $y_1 \neq y_2$; Not-Fun: two such members. | |

# Options and defaults

| option | default | effect |
|---|---|---|
| `--rels-functional-mode=uf\|pairs` | `uf` | how `rel.is-functional` is used |
| `--rels-acyclic-anchor=branch\|inclusion\|both\|none` | `branch` | anchor rules |
| `--rels-acyclic-backward-chords` | off | Backward (minimality) |
| `--rels-tc-subset` | off | closure induction |
| `--rels-tc-down-lazy` | off | TC-Down only at last call |
| `--rels-acyclic-hammer` | off | no TC-Down / Join-Split; grounding conflicts |
| `--sets-exp` ⇒ MiniSat | on | SAT solver unless set by the user or the problem is sygus-style |

All six new options are expert options, off or at their previous behaviour by default. The closure rules that need them (closure induction, lazy split, hammer) win on the benchmarks only in combination (next section); turning them on by default needs a broader evaluation (e.g. on cvc5/sets-and-relations-benchmarks).

# Setup

| name | options (all on the files without `:finite-model-find`) |
|---|---|
| default | `--finite-model-find` (as published) |
| FMF | default + `--e-matching --inst-when=full-delay --rels-acyclic-anchor=inclusion --rels-acyclic-backward-chords` |
| noFMF | `--rels-acyclic-anchor=inclusion --inst-when=full-delay --rels-acyclic-backward-chords` |
| stop-only | default + `--decision=stoponly` |
| FMF+R | FMF + R + `--rels-tc-down-lazy` |
| noFMF+R | noFMF + R + `--rels-tc-down-lazy` |
| noFMF+H | noFMF + R + `--rels-acyclic-hammer` |

R = `--prenex-quant=none --rels-tc-subset`.

- 13 benchmarks with `rel.cyclic` and `rel.is-functional` (relational-solver-benchmarks e4a4f7e), release build of the branch (6094bb5747), 300 s.
- **Virtual portfolio**: every pair (benchmark, configuration) on its own, 6 at a time; per benchmark the fastest configuration counts.
- **Real portfolio**: all 7 configurations started together; the first sat/unsat wins.

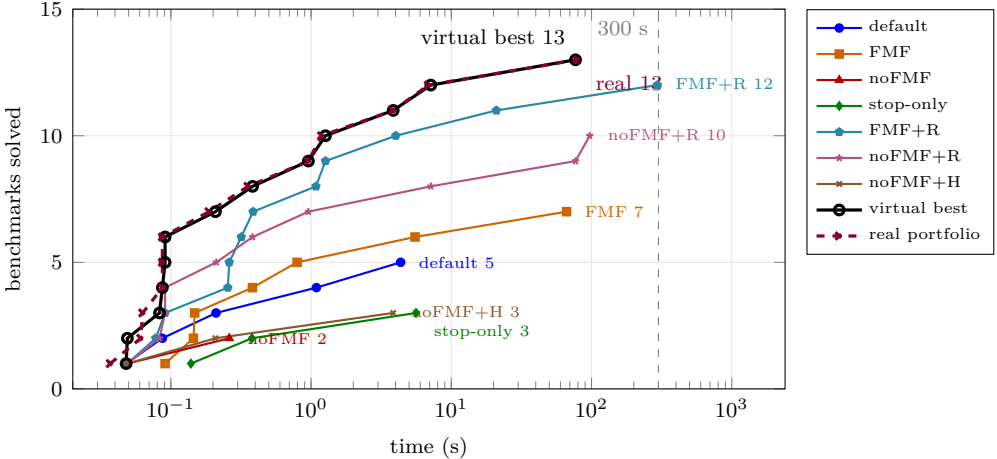
`scripts/portfolio.py` runs both modes; `scripts/slides/make_figures.py` makes the following tables and plots.

# Every configuration on every benchmark (virtual portfolio)

| benchmark | exp. | default | FMF | noFMF | stop-only | FMF+R | noFMF+R | noFMF+H | by | fastest |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| sc-1-th | unsat | timeout | unsat 0.80 | timeout | timeout | unsat 0.39 | **unsat 0.09** | timeout | 3 | 0.09 s |
| sc-1-th-just-rf | unsat | unsat 0.21 | unsat 0.14 | **unsat 0.05** | unsat 5.60 | unsat 0.08 | unsat 0.05 | unsat 0.05 | 7 | 0.05 s |
| sc-1-th-no-ltts | sat | **sat 0.05** | sat 0.09 | unknown | sat 0.14 | sat 0.05 | unknown | timeout | 4 | 0.05 s |
| sc-2-th | unsat | timeout | timeout | timeout | timeout | unsat 21.0 | unsat 97.1 | **unsat 3.85** | 3 | 3.85 s |
| sc-2-th-just-rf | unsat | unsat 1.09 | unsat 0.38 | unsat 0.26 | timeout | unsat 0.26 | unsat 0.21 | **unsat 0.21** | 6 | 0.21 s |
| plsc-1-th | unsat | timeout | unsat 5.51 | timeout | timeout | unsat 4.02 | **unsat 0.96** | timeout | 3 | 0.96 s |
| plsc-1-th-just-rf | unsat | timeout | timeout | timeout | timeout | unsat 0.32 | **unsat 0.09** | timeout | 2 | 0.09 s |
| plsc-1-th-no-ltts | sat | **sat 0.09** | sat 0.15 | unknown | sat 0.38 | sat 0.09 | unknown | timeout | 4 | 0.09 s |
| plsc-2-th | unsat | timeout | timeout | timeout | timeout | timeout | **unsat 76.9** | timeout | 1 | 76.9 s |
| plsc-2-th-just-rf | unsat | timeout | timeout | timeout | timeout | unsat 1.08 | **unsat 0.38** | timeout | 2 | 0.38 s |
| tso-1-th | unsat | timeout | timeout | timeout | timeout | unsat 294.6 | **unsat 7.14** | timeout | 2 | 7.14 s |
| tso-1-th-just-rf | unsat | timeout | unsat 66.4 | timeout | timeout | unsat 0.26 | **unsat 0.08** | timeout | 3 | 0.08 s |
| tso-1-th-no-ltts | sat | sat 4.35 | timeout | unknown | timeout | **sat 1.27** | timeout | timeout | 2 | 1.27 s |
| solved | | 5 | 7 | 2 | 3 | 12 | 10 | 3 | **13 of 13** | |

300 s per run. Bold: the fastest configuration, which the virtual best takes. “by”: how many configurations solve the file. 0 wrong answers. The best single configuration (FMF+R) solves 12; the portfolio solves **13 of 13**. plsc-2-th is solved by noFMF+R only.

# The portfolio as a cactus plot

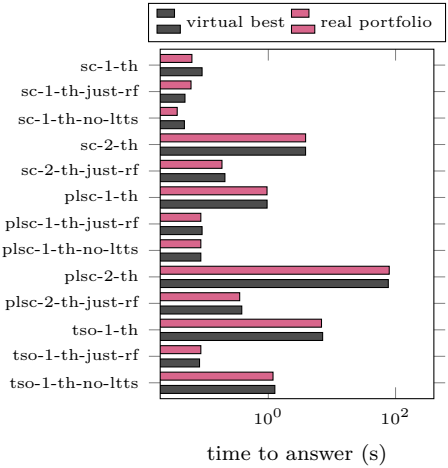



Each curve: one configuration's solve times, sorted; cumulative count; final count at its right end. Virtual best: per file the fastest configuration. Real: all 7 started together.

# Virtual best versus real portfolio

| benchmark | winner | VBS | real | CPU |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| sc-1-th | noFMF+R | 0.09 s | 0.06 s | 0.4 s |
| sc-1-th-just-rf | noFMF | 0.05 s | 0.06 s | 0.3 s |
| sc-1-th-no-ltts | default | 0.05 s | 0.04 s | 0.2 s |
| sc-2-th | noFMF+H | 3.85 s | 3.86 s | 27.0 s |
| sc-2-th-just-rf | noFMF+H / noFMF+R | 0.21 s | 0.19 s | 1.2 s |
| plsc-1-th | noFMF+R | 0.96 s | 0.95 s | 6.7 s |
| plsc-1-th-just-rf | noFMF+R | 0.09 s | 0.09 s | 0.6 s |
| plsc-1-th-no-ltts | default | 0.09 s | 0.09 s | 0.6 s |
| plsc-2-th | noFMF+R | 76.9 s | 79.5 s | 556.4 s |
| plsc-2-th-just-rf | noFMF+R | 0.38 s | 0.35 s | 2.5 s |
| tso-1-th | noFMF+R | 7.14 s | 6.86 s | 48.0 s |
| tso-1-th-just-rf | noFMF+R | 0.08 s | 0.09 s | 0.5 s |
| tso-1-th-no-ltts | FMF+R | 1.27 s | 1.19 s | 7.1 s |

Virtual: 13 of 13. Real: 13 of 13, with the same winner on 12; real/virtual between 0.69 and 1.24 (median 0.96). Ratios below 1: the virtual runs also share the CPU (6 at a time).




Every real answer within 79.5 s. plsc-2-th needs 53 s on a fast core, 286 s on an efficiency core.

# Testing

- **Regressions**: 53 new or changed files; all 443 sets, relations and bags regressions and all 2800 `regress0` tests pass with assertions on.
- **Proofs**: the CPC proofs of all 84 applicable unsat relations regressions check with ethos; `garbage_collect.cvc` times out, as on main. The check found that `rel.rclosure`, `rel.rtclosure` were missing from the CPC signature (added).
- **Fuzzing** against brute force: 5 500 random problems (`rel.cyclic` of unions, nested either way, `(not (rel.cyclic S))`, pairs forced in, out, or free) under five option sets: no wrong answer, no error.
- **Bugs found on the way, fixed in this PR**:
  - the join grounding conflict refuted satisfiable branches under the hammer: first for lack of distinctness, then, for a membership on a set $S$ equal to the join only in the current branch, for lack of the premise $S = A; B$;
  - `rel.rclosure` of a union crashed debug builds, and of a variable answered `sat` wrongly (now `unknown`);
  - the MiniSat default answered `unsat` wrongly with `:produce-interpolants` (a latent issue, also on main with `--sat-solver=minisat`); the default now skips sygus-style problems.
- **CI**: formatting (clang-format 22, whole files) and the CPC/Logos check pass.

# Contributions

- Two predicates for relational specifications, `rel.cyclic` and `rel.is-functional`, with API, parser, printer, type rules, rewrites, CPC declarations and documentation.
- A calculus for them in the relations solver:
  - a cycle witness that is a shortest cycle of the operands' closures, unrolled one element per round and completed from the model;
  - acyclicity, and anchors that connect cyclic and acyclic constraints;
  - closure induction, which proves closure memberships without fresh elements;
  - functionality by a skolem function;
  - lazy and grounded closure reasoning.
- A strategy that places each rule: context rules at full effort, model-dependent rules at last call.
- On the 13 litmus-template benchmarks: **13 of 13** solved by the portfolio (virtual and real), no wrong answer.

# Where to find it

- PR to cvc5 main: `mudathirmahgoub/cvc5#17` (branch `cycle-ext-cyclic`); the same branch is `rachelcleaveland/cvc5#9`, stacked on the earlier `cycle-ext` PRs.
- Benchmarks: `rachelcleaveland/relational-solver-benchmarks`, directories `benchmarks-ltts` and `benchmarks-ltts-nofmf`.
- Temporary, to be deleted before merging: `scripts/` (portfolio runner, ablation, comparison, converters) and `scripts/slides/` (this deck, its figure generator and the run data).
- Rebuild the deck: `cd scripts/slides; python3 make_figures.py data/final-300s figures; pdflatex relations-pr.tex`.